capabilities, but instead focused on the ten-year gap in the testing cycle (China tested in 1964 and India in 1974), in order to justify their contention that in 1968, when the NPT was adopted, India did not have the capacity to test a nuclear weapon and, hence, could not be a nuclear weapons state under the NPT. This is the perception they wished to create even though the reality was different. Declassified papers show that India's chief atomic scientist, Homi J. Bhabha, had written letters to Prime Minister Nehru in 1963 about India possessing the capability to test a nuclear weapon. [2]

The Americans were independently aware of India's capabilities in that regard. A telegram from the US State Department in March 1966 referred to the probability that India would be in a position to test a nuclear device within a year of such a political decision being made by the Indian leadership. [3] The reason for India not testing before the NPT was signed in 1968 was not, perhaps, because India did not possess the technology; it lay elsewhere. India was seeking iron-clad guarantees from the Americans and the Soviets that they would individually or together come to India's assistance in the event of a Chinese attack. Prime Ministers Lal Bahadur Shastri and Indira Gandhi actively explored this possibility with the Johnson administration.

There were conversations in Delhi between US Special Envoy Averell Harriman and Shastri in 1965, [4] and between the Indian Prime Minister's Secretary L.K. Jha and President Johnson in 1967. [5] America refused to give specific guarantees, mainly out of concern that exclusive nuclear guarantees to India would alienate Pakistan, which was a strategic ally. A memo in this regard from General Curtis LeMay, Acting Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff, to Robert McNamara, Secretary of Defence, became the foundation of US nuclear policy towards India. [6] In short, India not testing a nuclear device before 1968 may have